



Jackson Downtown Development Authority

Board Meeting

Minutes

Thursday, April 9, 2026

8am, City Hall–10th Floor, Jackson, MI

"Empower the DDA District by encouraging a vibrant and diverse environment and creating memorable experiences that strengthen our local economy, support businesses and engage residents."

I. Call to order, notation of members present

The meeting was called to order at 8:05 a.m. by B. Kuiper

Members Present: T. Loveberry, T. Christoff, D. Roof, J. Butterfield, B. Johncox, F. Dancy, M. Moore, S. Pienta

Members Absent: S. Toler, K. Sharrer

Staff Present:

B. Kuiper – DDA Executive Director

M. Evans – Event & Economic Sustainability Specialist

City Manager: J. Greene

Others Present: Brad LaFollette from Blue Fig Artisan

II. Public Comments: No comments

III. Presentation: None

IV. Regular Business

A. DDA Board Meeting Minutes, February 12, 2026 Meeting

Motion to approve: J. Butterfield

Second: D. Roof

All ayes. Motion carried.

B. Acceptance of January and February Financials

Motion to approve: J. Butterfield

Second: T. Loveberry

All ayes. Motion carried.

C. City of Jackson Update— J. Greene: Hayes Hotel redevelopment is progressing with support from the State of Michigan, Senator Sue Shink, and State Representative Kathy Schmaltz. Meetings regarding East Side development are anticipated next quarter, with potential involvement from the Board. Henry Ford Health has expressed interest in contributing resources to the East Side, working to identify community needs and support ongoing infrastructure and housing efforts.

There was discussion regarding homelessness in the downtown area. It was noted that this is a broader community issue, not illegal, and reflects larger systemic challenges. Conversations

are ongoing to better understand needs, communicate with business owners, and encourage patience as the situation continues to be addressed.

City of Jackson 10-Year Master Plan: Participation from community members is encouraged to ensure diverse input. Being part of the process is critical. Community feedback is valuable and will help shape the long-term plan, recognizing that progress will take time.

V. New Business

- A. Cruise-In & Concert volunteer sign-up & thank you cards passed around
- B. 2026/27 FY DDA Proposed Budget: B. Johncox presented the February financial report, including a three-year outlook. The 2026/27 proposed budget aligns with that report and prior discussions, with minor adjustments based on current trends. Revenue reflects a slight increase outside of sponsorships, consistent with the 15% growth target, and includes approximately \$40,000 in unredeemed gift certificates. Expenses also show a slight increase, with staffing adjustments reflecting changes in wages, including the removal of Dodi's salary.

Motion to approve the 2026/27 proposed budget as presented

Motion to approve: J. Butterfield

Second: S. Pienta

All ayes. Motion carried.

- C. MLCC —Special Event License: Motion to approve the Special Event License for May 14, 4:00–8:00 PM.

Motion to approve: T. Loveberry

Second: J. Butterfield

All ayes. Motion carried.

- D. Facade Loan/Grant Program Application—Blue Fig Artisan: Brad LaFollette, owner of Blue Fig Artisan, a high-end cabinetry company located in the former Howard's Feed Store (est. 1886), presented the project. The building has served multiple uses over time, including a Coca-Cola presence, hotel extension, and auto mechanic shop. Proposed improvements include exterior updates to unify the façade, relocation of the entrance for ADA compliance, and installation of additional windows to enhance visibility and create a more inviting, customer-focused retail environment. The project aims to establish a stronger point of entry and draw more people into the space.

Motion to approve \$1,000 rendering grant: T. Loveberry

Second: S. Pienta

All ayes. Motion carried.

Motion to approve the facade grant application for \$15,000 through the Facade

Load/Grant Program for Blue Fig Artisan: S. Pienta

Second: M. Moore

All ayes. Motion carried.

Facade Evaluations Matrix: The Board discussed use of the evaluation matrix as a reference for the review and alignment with program goals, including preservation of historical elements.

- E. DDA additional staff member request -

Motion to authorize a new employee; not to exceed the current budget for salaries: S.

Pienta

Second: M. Moore

All ayes. Motion carried.

- F. DDA scorecard -

Staff are catching up on outstanding story content with community input. Updated maps, including parking, are in progress. A grant application has been submitted for speaker system improvements.

VI. Staff Report

- A. Director Report—B. Kuiper (Report attached) - Staff will attend training in Tulsa next week and will prepare a presentation following. Events are progressing as planned; the first event was well received, with subsequent events showing varied engagement. Board suggestions for expansion included introducing a late-afternoon happy hour, noting that early-month timing presents increased competition. Additional considerations include extending event offerings and exploring billboard promotion.

VII. Board Member Announcements

- A. Member Announcements—None

VIII. Future DDA Board Meetings

- A. Board Meeting: June 11, 2026 (8a., City Hall – 10th Floor Conference Room)
- B. Executive Committee Meeting: April 28 and May 26, 2026 (10a, City Hall – 6th Floor)

IX. Adjournment: Motion to adjourn the meeting at 9:19 a.m.

Motion: T. Loveberry

Second: D. Roof